

AAHP 725B Memorial Service Newberry Six 8-18-2019
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Abstract: This is a recording and transcription of the service held at Pleasant Plain United Methodist Church in Newberry, Florida, to commemorate and honor the lives of the six African Americans that were lynched in the town in 1916. The program, consisting of prayers, poems, and history, tells the story of the Black community in North Central Florida and serves as an homage to these individuals, their families, and the countless others who have experienced racism and violence. By recognizing the truth of the past, the presenters discuss the atrocities of slavery in the United States and leave the audience with a message of hope for unity, equality, and justice.

Keywords: [Newberry Six memorial, lynching, racism, violence, slavery, Jim Crow]

SAMUEL PROCTOR
ORAL HISTORY
PROGRAM
University of Florida

G: As we begin this service, let me introduce myself. I'm Brother Milford L. Griner. I'm on the program, but I'm standing now in place of Pastor Rivers, and I'm standing because, I'm a former two-time pastor of this church. I served a total of twelve years here as a pastor, from 1997 to 2003, then I went to pastor other churches, and then came back and pastored here from 2010 until 2016. And as you see in the program, I'm also founder and president of the Rosa Parks Quiet Courage Committee. So, Pastor Rivers could not be here, so I'm standing in his place, as a fellow pastor, and as a former pastor, of this great church. So when I come up here, I'm home. Amen. Well, it's good to be here and in absence of Pastor Rivers, to welcome all of you to this very important gathering. And I know that the, he—Pastor's not here in person, but I know he's here in spirit. So again, on behalf of Pastor Rivers and all those of Pleasant Lane, you are indeed welcomed to this program. And at this time, we're going to ask that you just bow your heads as we now enter into a brief invocation. "Oh, most holy and everlasting God, we want to first thank you for allowing us to assemble in this place, to remember and to pay honor to those who were the victims of hate and violence, that unfortunately, we are still experiencing to this day. We know that you're in our midst, and we would add that you are, in your holy way, lead and guide this program, that all of us may know how important it is. For, in words of Dr. Martin Luther King Jr., either we will learn to live together as brothers and sisters, or we will surely perish together as fools. Again, thank you for the gathering and all of those who braved the **inclement** weather to be here for this occasion, and all the participants who are here—all the guests, special guests,

clergymen—with all those who understand how important it is to never forget that we might be able to live and work in a spirit of unity and reconciliation. For truly, that's what is needed in this nation and world we live in today. So we say thank you, and all praise and honor due to you, in Jesus' name we pray. Amen." Amen. Then we'll turn it on over to our presider, my good and longtime friend, Ms. Sherry DuPree, who will now lead us in the order of service.

SD: Thank you, Brother Griner. We've known each other probably thirty plus years. We worked together out at Santa Fe years ago. I see some other Santa Fe people in here as well. So, I say thank you for this opportunity. Our song is the Negro national anthem, and I was looking for—here she is, over in the corner there [laughter] I would like for you, Vivian, to come over to the microphone and lead us in our Negro National Anthem. And she can also give us the history of the Negro National Anthem, would you like to share a little bit of history first?

F: Yes ma'am.

SD: Thank you.

F: I'd rather share the history than sing, but here's what. The Negro National Anthem came about because Jay Rosalind Johnson and Pope and his brother, were the sons of a lady who was Jamaican, actually, she came to the United States, married their father, and had these two children, and decided to go to school to be a schoolteacher, which she did. And one year, they were celebrating the birthday of Abraham Lincoln, and she wanted a special song for that occasion. So isn't this a marvelous thing, she has one—asked them for a song, one son wrote the words and the other one wrote the music to this great song.

So, it was sung that day and, over time, it became so popular—she belonged to the NAACP and convinced them to take this song on as our song, because you realize, the National Anthem didn't speak to us—and now that I know what I know about the National Anthem—it really didn't speak to us. But this song, this song, gets to the heart of who we are. The first verse tells us not to give up, just to lift our voice no matter what, and the second verse talks about the hardship, stony the road we trod, but the last verse is a prayer and it's done softly—God of our weary ears, God of our silent tears. So, when we take that all into account, this song became the Negro National Anthem, sung at all the big events, at all the schools and all the churches, everywhere that we went, and a glorious sound was always heard. In my school, it was two, three, four-part harmony, and just a capella, because this song meant a lot to a lot of people, so we didn't have to use a paper, we had to learn it. So, we don't need to lose this piece of history—I'm sorry I said so much, but if you would stand in recognition of the Negro National Anthem. [Singing]

Lift ev'ry voice and sing,

'Til earth and heaven ring,

Ring with the harmonies of Liberty;

Let our rejoicing rise

High as the list'ning skies,

Let it resound loud as the rolling sea.

Sing a song full of the faith that the dark past has taught us,

Sing a song full of the hope that the present has brought us;

*Facing the rising sun of our new day begun,
Let us march on 'til victory is won.*

*Stony the road we trod,
Bitter the chastening rod,
Felt in the days when hope unborn had died;
Yet with a steady beat,
Have not our weary feet
Come to the place for which our fathers sighed?
We have come over a way that with tears has been watered,
We have come, treading our path through the blood of the slaughtered,
Out from the gloomy past,
'Til now we stand at last
Where the white gleam of our bright star is cast.*

*God of our weary years,
God of our silent tears,
Thou who has brought us thus far on the way;
Thou who has by Thy might
Led us into the light,
Keep us forever in the path, we pray.
Lest our feet stray from the places, our God, where we met Thee,
Lest our hearts drunk with the wine of the world, we forget Thee;*

Shadowed beneath Thy hand,

May we forever stand,

True to our God,

True to our native land

[End of song]

V: Thank you.

SD: The moral occasion for the Newberry Six victims. The Newberry Six victims and other victims of racial violence need to be included today as well. This activity, of course, is at the Pleasant Plains United Methodist Church in Newberry, Florida, but the area is known as Jonesville, Florida. On the front of your program, you see the national memorial for peace and justice, which is in Montgomery, Alabama. [Microphone feedback] Alright, we were mentioning about the national memorial for peace and justice in Montgomery, Alabama. It stands for the hanged and beaten, for the shot, drowned, and burned, for the tortured, tormented, and terrorized, for those abandoned by the rule of law, we will remember, with hope, because hopelessness is the enemy of justice, with courage, because peace requires bravery, with resistance, because justice is a constant struggle, with faith, because we shall overcome. [Feedback, background noise] Can y'all hear me? We are here for many occasions today, and I'm going to start by saying, we joined the national observance of four hundred years, the anniversary of 1619, arriving the first captive African Americans in the British colonies in North America, at Fort Comfort in Virginia. This launched the saga of slavery, racism, and resistance in the United States of

America. Four hundred years we've had these issues to deal with. Joining the global observance of the 25th anniversary of the UNESCO slave route, this was launched at Benin in West Africa in 1994, as an international call to all nations to remember the history of the slave trade, and to know the stories, that they will not be forgotten. Yes, there was another observation that I must mention, the anniversary of the start of the victorious Haitian Revolution in 1791, which would bring about the abolition of slavery, of the slave trade. This was double the size of the United States and became a beacon of hope for freedom and independence throughout the hemisphere, observed the red summer that was in 1919 in the United States. Yes, we know about Chicago, we know about so many other places where we had red summers as well—riots, eruptions, all across this nation. But we've come into Florida today, and we've come into Florida to talk about and to remember the Newberry Six. This was in 1916. 1916—three years, so it's a hundred and three years ago, that this happened right here in this area where we're sitting today and in this community. So, it is very fitting that we have this program, that we recognize these folks who gave their lives—all of them were innocent, all of them were good citizens. They had their own homes, they had land out here, they took care of each other. It was a community—and when we live in a community, we help one another. And those six names I will read—Jim Dennis—there's a light for him—Stella Young, Mary Dennis, Bert Dennis, Reverend Josh Baskins, it has J.J. Baskins, and Andrew McHenry—those are the six that we're honoring today, but there's so many more that were killed during that time span, dealing with the early part after the World War I, and then

dealing also in this area with the Boll weevil that came here in 1916 and before. And the Boll weevil was killing the crops with with your cotton. So, there were many reasons why we think the Newberry Six occurred, because people had to keep their sense of place, and they had to keep their sense of wealth, and they did not have the money that they had had in previous years. So, this occurred—I will not give you the story, because that will be shared later—but the main thing is, I want you to remember that we are here today for the Newberry Six family. Thank you. And next, we are going to have our Newberry Six family recognition by Mr. Wyard Dennis. Would you please come up, Deacon? He is the deacon of Second Morning Star Missionary Baptist Church. [Applause] Thank you. Well, I want you to introduce any of the family members that are here.

WD: Well, my name is Wyard Dennis Jr., I am the grandson of Jim Dennis, which was one of the six, and the cousins of—let me get the names right—of Mary Dennis and Bert Dennis, were cousins. And I am here to tell you all, God has brought us a long way, and I thank God for it, and I thank all of you people for supporting this and making this what it is. And we continue to trust in the Lord and do good to each other, and love each other, 'cause love is the main thing—if you got love, you ain't got nothing to worry about, everything's gonna come fall into place. Thank you. [Applause]

SD: Thank you. If you have other family members here, would you please stand? The Long family said they were coming, I guess they haven't made it yet. Any family members here, would you please stand? Alright, at this time we'll come back to the—do we have someone here?

U: We're all family. [Laughter]

SD: Oh, yes we are, but I'm thinking in terms of the Newberry Six family right now.

U: Yes, yes, I know [inaudible 18:18].

SD: Yes, yes, and a beautiful family and the community that we are, and I thank you each of you for being here today. Our next portion is Truth and Reconciliation.

Mayor Jordan Marlowe, he is the mayor of Newberry, Florida. [Applause]

M: I may not need this microphone, but I'll stand here just in case. I didn't bring any prepared comments today, because honestly, this is starting to feel like family. And for me, that's exactly what truth and reconciliation is intended to do; is to rebuild a community back into a family, which is what we were always intended and called to be. We're here today to memorialize, and we're here today to remember, but I would also very humbly suggest that today, finally, we can celebrate that we are here together, and we're here together openly talking about and admitting something that happened over a century ago. A hundred and two years ago, crimes were committed that caused a pain that ran so deep in this community that it has kept us at odds and at bay ever since. It is a pain that runs so deep that it would probably be difficult for anybody here to articulate exactly all of the problems that have stemmed from that pain. And, you know, part of our community has pretended, part of our community has ignored, and then we got to the place where we said, "Well, it happened so long ago, let's leave it back there. Let's not bring it, let's not talking about it anymore." And the problem with that is that when members of a family experience pain, and we don't address it, then it didn't happen a hundred and three years ago, it's still happening today.

So, I'm proud at the little piece of celebration that I would humbly submit to you is that we have at least gotten to the point where we have admitted that this happened, we recognized the truth, and we have apologized. Now for me—my kids are sitting in the back right there, and for those of you don't know, I'm a student at Newberry—I'm a teacher [laughter]—but I teach my students that apologies are empty words, without action and without change. So, it is wonderful to apologize, and it is absolutely a first step, but it's not the end step, it's not the last step, it's the beginning of a new chapter. And it's that beginning that will allow us to truly become the family that I believe we always have been. We've just been estranged, and it's time to rebuild the bonds. So about two years ago, some community members came to me and they said that they wanted to embark on this process, they said that it was time, and I agree. Been a hundred and two years, and that first conversation has led to action in the city of Newberry, not empty words. We have come together in new ways to build new memories, new bonds of friendship and family. And I'll just share one of those activities with you, because it just happened. We took a busload of folks to Montgomery, Alabama—it's pictured on the front of your program today—and I want to share this story, I'm not going to tell you about the whole trip, that would take too long, but we had a bus that was going to take us and that bus broke down, so another bus picked us up. The first bus was from a local church, the one that broke down, another bus came from another local church to pick us up. We got all the way, just past Lake City, and that bus broke down. [Laughter] And before we were stopped on the side of the road, we had two other buses headed

towards us to pick us up and take us the way. Now, I share that with you because, to me, this trip that we took was a metaphor for truth and reconciliation. It took an awful lot of planning and struggle to get it started, it had a rocky and rough beginning, a lot of times I'm sure a lot of folks on that bus thought we weren't gonna make it, but we persevered. We did not let obstacles prevent us from getting there. And when we got there, this group was so adventurous and so dedicated, we didn't say we're just going to go to Montgomery, Alabama, we went further to Selma. And we went to Selma, and we experienced that, and then we were able to come back with each other. That whole bus ride ended up being about seven hours there, seven hours back, if you take out all the breakdowns. And in that time, we shared stories of why we were on the bus together, why we believed in the process that we were working on together. And this process of truth and reconciliation is not about wiping away the past, it's not about covering up the past, it's about bringing out the truth of the past and then building new bonds together to move us into the future, shared experiences, shared memories, shared bonds of familial community. So, I'm very proud of you, really, I'm proud of this community that has come together and recognized that it's time to work on this, that it's time to admit it, that it's time to discuss it. And I'm not going to ask for it today, because I don't believe that we've earned it yet. When we had the unveiling of the marker, it was a pleasure to finally be able to stand in a public forum and say I'm sorry, as I believe any human of compassion would do, for what happened in 1916. But one day—and I do not know when that day will be—but one day, I'll stand in front of you and I'll ask for forgiveness. But

before I ask for that, we have a lot more work to do, and today is part of that work. So, thank you for coming, thank you for everybody who helped to host it, and I look forward to the rest of the ceremony. [Applause]

G: As I come back up here, let me say—while I've been a pastor for the past thirty-six years in Alachua and Marion County, I've also had occasion to occasionally write poetry over that time, and also, when I heard about this program, given my long history of this church and this area, I had to be here. So, I'm proud to be able to share an original poem that I wrote back in 1987 and that has undergone revisions, which I just, I did one for this occasion, and I'd like to share it with you now. It's titled "Come My People"—again, first written and shared in 1987.

[Begins poem] *Come, my people, to the land that is free, the land of brotherhood and justice for you and for me. Come, my people, let us make our mark and show others we will not remain in the dark. Come, my people, come. Come, my people, there's work to be done. Bridges to cross, victories to be won, to the land that is free with heads held high, we won't be stopped until we reach the sky. Come, my people, to the land that's free, the land of understanding of reality. No expectance, just acceptance, no waiting or debating, just relating and rejoicing in the land that is free. Come, my people, let us set our sights, reaching those goals on climbing the heights. Come, let us show the world our determination to succeed in the face of discrimination, to clear our names of all incrimination. In pursuing our dreams there is no shame, long as we pursue them in God's name. We have the power to chart our course by using what Martin Luther King called "soul force." Come, my people, we must not delay. Martin Luther King had a*

dream, keep it alive today. All the haters and evil doers have better be aware, the smell of freedom and equality is in the air. All of the racist groups and clubs have better know today that no matter what you do, you will not have the final say.

Come, my people, keep the dream alive. Let's make our mark, for we must live, to be the best we can always as we live our lives, for God is always on our side and by His Word, we must all abide. Come, my people, let's shout and let's sing, we'll be better off when we let freedom ring. Come, my people, to the land that is free.

[End of poem] Thank you, God bless you. [Applause]

SD: Thank you so much. Like I said, I've known this gentleman— we've known each other for many, many, many years. And now, we will move to the next part of our program. This is the history of the Newberry Six lynchings, with Dr. Patricia Hilliard-Nunn, professor of African and African American Studies at the University of Florida. [Applause]

H: Thank you, Sherry. Now, first and foremost, I give thanks just for life, health, and strength just to be able to be here. Next, I just want to say I don't feel no ways tired. Come too far, we've all come too far from where we've started from, and nobody told us that this road was gonna be easy, but I don't believe that he brought us this far to leave us. So, thank you for the opportunity to just share this again. Obviously, I can't share all of that history in three minutes, right, and originally, I was thinking we would be outside and you could read the marker and get that history, but I'll give you a little taste because there's some people who probably haven't heard me, just some of you are probably like "There she goes again with the broken record." And so, I just am pleased to be able to be here.

Because we do, we stand on the shoulders of giants, and of people whose stories should have been told a long time ago, but in many ways they have been being told. Last night, I was with Mayor Marlowe at the Rosewood Banquet, saw a beautiful play—some of the actors and actresses are here—who taught people about what happened just up the road from here after the Newberry Six lynching. And the thing that struck me during that play—which was very powerful—because it was, the drama of it was acted out in the story—is that when we tell the stories of the trauma—and it was terrorism—the other people dealt with and they're still dealing with, is that we don't always talk about these are people who came from powerful communities of, thriving communities, people who laid the very foundations upon which we stand today, that when we talk about this area that we're sitting in today, the Jonesville community—people say the Newberry Six, but it was people taken from the Jonesville community, which was predominantly Black people living out here—some were the descendants of those who had been enslaved on plantations in Alachua County. And you all know, Alachua County was the seventh-largest slave owning county in the state of Florida, and many of those plantations were here, including the Jones plantation, which Jonesville was named after. So, when we look at that history, we see these relationships between some of the people who were lynched and some of the families of the lynchers, who have gone back to the plantation times. And people who have done research have demonstrated that, in many places where lynchings took place, those were also the places that had plantations. The most of them have—there's this correlation between plantation territory and

lynching territory. The other point I just want to make at the start is that Florida had the highest per capita rate of lynching in the United States of America. And it was not Mississippi, it was not Alabama, but it was Florida and, in that number, it was Alachua County that was at the top of that—not the top, but you know, probably the third, we think, on that list. And so, if we can put that into context and envision us coming out of that period of slavery into reconstruction, and people set about establishing churches here—they had worshipped during the period of enslavement, they had schools out here, there were families here thriving—and I thought about that today, I was at service here at Pleasant Plains today, and I'm so thankful to Pleasant Plains United Methodist Church—they've been so busy the last week, back-to-school program, funerals, everything—and so, no rest for the weary, I appreciate them. But this year, in April, they worked hard, and it took a lot of planning, but they decided that it was time to erect a historic marker to commemorate those people who were lynched in 1916, some of whom are buried in the cemetery that's directly behind us here. And so, the marker is here on that property to honor the work and the brilliance, the tenacity, of those workers who worked here, right here in Jonesville. They weren't just the hired help, they were running their businesses. Many people from this community would go into Gainesville, and they were teachers, they were pastors, they were agriculturalists—who do you think ran the farms during slavery, right? And they were land owners. And so—but we know in the case of many lynchings, they took place because people wanted their land. And there was often a rouse to trick people out of their land, and because it was during that period of Jim Crow,

where African Americans didn't have any rights, they could get away with it. In fact, there were many cases where people would take the land, you know, take other people's and they say, "Okay, well, you can just have it." You can **overwrite it, you can have**—what is the person going to do? So, by the time we get to 1916—and of course, I have to jump over a lot of information here and you're talking about the phosphate mines, you're talking about people working, living side by side, descendants of slave holders, descendants of—some of the people who had been alive during the period of slavery were still alive during that time, they're living, working in these communities here, they have family all over Alachua County, they had relationships—and then we had the issue of somebody accused somebody of stealing hogs, or being a part of a hog stealing ring, okay? And this is a story that we continue to tell in connection with the Newberry lynching. And so, we may never know the full truth of what happened that night, but just quickly, just to recount a few points, and then I will wrap—on that night—and this is the day, this is what August 18th a hundred and three years ago, we had a case where Sheriff George **Winn**, who happened to be the youngest brother of the—it gets complicated, I'm looking at my friend Janice back there—because you know, everybody in Alachua County is related, but how many of you—let me do it this way, how many have heard of the Dudley Plantation? Okay, the Dudley Plantation—so they're all these connections and family relationships, so when we talk about the Dudley Plantation, you're talking about a family of people who were here since the period of slavery, who worked—in some cases employed some African Americans on their plantation—

but what happened was the wife at the time, the matriarch of the family, was the sister of the constable, one of the constables here in Newberry. Well, that person, George **Winn** went to—supposedly, allegedly—went to issue a warrant to, or to question they say, not even a warrant, to question a man named Boise Long. And Boise Long lived in this area, in the Jonesville community. Well, guess what? They show up, and he and a couple of other people show up, at about two o'clock A.M. in the morning, to issue this warrant, or you know, to question him about stealing hogs. Well, what we know happened is that Boise Long wound up shooting them, they wound up—somebody shot Boise Long, he was hurt, Boise Long got away, Sheriff Winn ultimately died from his wounds as they were trying to get him medical help. Well, here you have the death of a law enforcement officer who was related to a prominent family in the community. Some people said, "Oh, they weren't that prominent." Yes, they were. There were not much but a handful of families here, and they were one of the most prominent ones, you know, they have a large family. So, what happened is they started rounding people up as they tried to locate Boise Long. So, they came into the Black community and started questioning people and started rounding up members, people who they believe were members of his family, and that included the people that we are memorializing here today, it included at least six people—the reason why I say Newberry lynchings is because we know at least two other people were killed in addition to the six that we talk about. They rounded them up—actually, there's one person who was killed earlier in the day on the eighteenth—and then the rest of them were rounded up that night and taken to

the jail, which still stands in Newberry today. And they held them there, somewhere during the night, by the early morning, they were taken out to the area called Lynch Hammock and they were hung from trees. One of the women, Mary Dennis, was pregnant at the time. Other people, **dark** people were told to stay inside because we're going around, they started rounding people up, and so everybody was scared, there are lots of side stories connected with this narrative that I won't get into right now, but they found the people down there at Lynch Hammock—some of you probably know about that area because when you drive past there, you get probably get an eerie feeling going through there, okay—and so, this is not a new story to come about, cause it's told to me by people like Albert White, people who've lived here, people who've known, people whose grandparents have been talking about it for years, okay? And so, they hung the people, people brought their children to witness it, we know that law enforcement was involved, we know that a state representative came down to witness it—you're talking about over a thousand people, you know, probably more than that, coming and looking at those bodies hanging there, hanging from the trees there. Children were brought out there and told to witness—we don't know what types of souvenirs they may have taken from the bodies of the people, which was a tradition at lynchings to often take a finger, sometimes they would mutilate the bodies—and part of the oral history goes that a strip was taken from the back of Reverend Josh Baskins to make a whip, and a local doctor bent down, cut the whip out of his back and said “I'm going to make a cracker out of this.” Okay? And so, there's nothing that those people could do, there was nothing that their

families could do—another one of the stories says that Reverend Josh Baskin said, “God, you know, they’re not gonna, they’re gonna kill me, there’s nothing that I can do, but will you please just light up this forest?” Just to show, you know, that they were wrong and they say that the forest somehow lit up when that happened. But I think that the key thing is that, I think that the saddest—that was sad enough, but the sadness extends—the horror or the terror was extended, because of the failure of the media that would—surprise, surprise, right? Because they were dishonest. They lied about it, and they said that these people were part of a hog stealing ring. And these two women, and—which is, which we know is a lie, because these are people who were farmers, who had their own animals, they sold their own animals, they grew their own food, they traded with different people—and part of the oral history is also that when the sheriff came to the house to get Boise Long, the person who—was not lynched, by the way, I’m gonna come back to him—he said, “Just take what you want. Take whatever hog you want. Go ahead, take it then.” You know, and he knew that it wasn’t their hog, he said, but take it because he knew that there would be trouble, and they didn’t take it. So, there was more to that story, which we’re continuing to uncover facts about, because of the silence that is still out there today, we’re still uncovering truths about what happened because people are still keeping the secrets **that pass** secrets on to their children and grandchildren, and they’re still not telling some of those things, okay? Sometimes they do right before they pass, but that’s not always the case. Nobody was ever charged with the lynching of these people. There was a trial held, there were people on a jury, there was a

judge—I already told you law enforcement participated in the lynching, we even know the names of at least two of the law enforcement officers who participated, one who helped tie the noose. Eventually, Boise Long turned himself in, and he turned himself into another Long **who he wasn't** related to, and they turned him in to Sheriff Ramsey in Gainesville. He was tried and convicted in eleven minutes, and then, you know, he was legally hung downtown, okay? But what had happened—cause when he was turned in, we believe that he turned himself in and was encouraged to turn himself in, because it was like, “Look, it's either you or it's the rest of the community,” you understand? So, it wasn't a matter of “Look, well, are you innocent, or are you guilty?” But it was a matter of “Wow, if I don't—if they don't get justice from me, they're gonna kill the whole, continue killing the entire family.” So, it brings us to today, which is what we're doing—and happy birthday Mayor Marlowe, it's his birthday—he was in the play last night, did a great job—but it's this principle of Sankofa, okay? Sankofa is a Ghanaian concept, which means go back and fetch it, or in order to move forward, you must first understand what happened before. And sometimes you'll see it depicted in many different ways, with different symbols—one is of a bird, I actually have it on my necklace, with a bird turning around with his head turned to the back, touching its tail feather. And sometimes that bird has an egg in its mouth, and that egg represents the rebirth. So, it's not to look back and live in the past, but it's to have a new rebirth, a positive rebirth, and to move forward in a positive light. And so therefore, it becomes important to have these memorials—we had one back in 2002 and people weren't really comfortable speaking, we did

have one for the one-hundred-year anniversary with Linda here at Pleasant Plain, and then the dedication of the historic marker back in April. So very important, but the purpose is to really counter those media lies about these people were stealing hogs, and to help us look at our condition today and say, "What if—I think, what if someone had said something at that time?" A lot of you in this room, I know, have asked that, with your own circumstances, but what if somebody had said something? Or didn't somebody say something? Or didn't somebody knows something? We have those situations taking place in 2019 today, and so it's comfortable to look at 1916 and say, yeah, now we're telling the truth about that. It's less comfortable when we look at the same propaganda being used to target certain people and misrepresent them, and they're being killed and we are silent about it. And so, we don't want our children in a hundred years from now to look back and say, "Well, what if somebody had said something? Why didn't they say something?" That's the most disturbing part of the whole thing to me, is the number of people who, even in 2019, know—even here in Newberry, what happened—they're living and they know, it's like "Well, I'm not gonna say anything." Now, it's a blessing family, cause this is family here, that more people are slowly beginning to open up because they understand how important that truth is. And so, I just—you know, it's nice to get together and to memorialize people, but I hope that you'll all encourage people that you know, who have information, to share that information as we move on. And so, that's the point, if you have other questions about that history, we can talk about that, I wanted to keep that short. But just remember that basic principle there, of

Sankofa, and understand that the telling of this story is not a new thing. It didn't start this year, didn't start last year—we've been doing this, and I've been here a while, I don't know how many years I've been, we've been talking about this and other incidents, because this lynching was not the only one that took place in Alachua County or in the state of Florida, that we know about. And with the Rosewood lynching, after all of that work, all of that research, what the courts did, before everything was done and they paid so-called reparations, they put a clause in there that said that after this case—what? —nobody else can sue and get compensation for things like the taking of the land, taking of the property, and things like that, regardless of if you know who did it. They're like "We're gonna pay this," but keep in mind, Florida has this deep, long history, and so they knew what kind of doors they were opening if they did that. So, thank you very much, thank you for coordinating the program, we still have work to do—family, I love you. [Applause]

SD: Thank you, thank you. Our next item will be Mr. Herbert C. DuPree, "The Madness," and that's my husband coming forward, so—[Applause]

HD: I'm gonna pass a picture around and you can look at it, and it has relevancy with respect to another poem I'm going to give you, "The Unkindness of Others," and then I'm going to give you a poem about the game children played in Chicago, and that's related to this one. I think—

U: Mr. Herbert, you need to come—

HD: I know, I just want to let them know and—well, look at it and then you may ask yourself, what's the relevancy of that, well it become relevant when you hear this

other poem, "The Unkindness of Others." [Begins poem] *It is hard to get through the day, when the night was thick with intrigue. Take a fresh mind into every day, minimizing the unkindness of others. Asking oneself, can one relive life's depository moments of happiness? Can we do the one thing which is required of us, walk humbly and seek that which is good? Or can we again bury our dreams, mute troubadours, fearing our own angry words? Or can we take a fresh mind into every new day, minimizing the unkindness of others.* [End of poem]

The games children play in Austin, Chicago, and—that's where the picture that's going around hopefully makes a little bit more sense—Austin, Chicago was one of the really, so-called nice neighborhoods in the [19]60s, and in Chicago, on the far west side of the city, and then it fell on very bad times—people talk about Inglewood, but Austin was equally troublesome in terms of the self-destruction that took place in the Black community. So, this is called "The Games of Black Children in Austin." [Begins poem] *Games the Black children in Austin are forgetting, tools for war weary children, full of sadness. Yet even these children may wander into unmarked territory, their frail bodies deposited in **Bare** Oak Cemetery. Predatory vultures seek those old enough to run, fast, with clarity, foot soldiers in a war zone. Betrayal of Black children has historical tentacles, Whites amazed at their young roughness, bemused by their cold stares, their grown-up cuss words, their stuttered steps when attempting to run in pants barely covering their knees. Whites say, "even these children are accountable". Even these children, solidly sneering, just one more link in the chain. Just one more link in the chain. Where other puppeteers with their elaborate sermons on forbidden*

fruit, busily seeking redemption for their own maladaptive behavior, Black children in Austin can play games as forgetting tools. Also rub the necks of grants and speak softly to minds, visiting other places and other times. [End of poem] And I like to end with "There's Madness." There was madness in 2016, and there's madness today. I like to start with the poem by the great Irish poet W.B. Yeats, "In Second Coming." [Begins poem] *Things fall apart, the center cannot hold. Mere anarchy is loosed upon the world. The blood-dimmed tide is loosed, and everywhere the ceremony of innocence is drowned, in the darkest chambers, at incomprehensive levels of anger. Madmen ponder martyrdom, profound despair glazes their minds, they sink in a pool of madness, holding rambling conversations with splintered acquaintances. Riddled minds descend into hell. After the madness, there are only mind faces. Cemetery menagerie on sunless days, mourners stepping stiffly, eyes ramrodded in grief, grief in its most organic form, grief that is measured, grief that is ritualistic and grief that is timeless.* [End of poem] Thank you. [Applause]

SD: Our memorial prayer. Rabbi Michael Joseph, from Temple Shir Shalom.

J: Good afternoon, it's such an honor to be here in this historic place, with this historic congregation. Part of the impetus for this afternoon's event came from a small, very informal group of Jewish and African American community leaders who've been meeting for about the last six months. Together we arranged a tour, an exploration of the Rosewood events led by Sherry just exactly a month ago, and also it seemed fitting to us to help create this memorial today. These prayers before you are taken pretty much word for word from the Jewish tradition, and I

hope you'll find them very universal in their sentiments. And I'd ask you to please rise, and please feel free to join together in honor of these words. We'll begin with this line from the prophet Isaiah. [Begins prayer in Hebrew] *I will give them in my house and within my walls a monument and a name better than sons and daughters; I will give them an everlasting name that shall not perish.* [Continues prayer in Hebrew] *God full of compassion, eternal spirit of the universe, grant perfect rest in your sheltering presence, to all our holy and pure brothers and sisters whose blood was spilled because of the color of their skin, both here in Newberry and throughout North Central Florida. God of mercy, may they find refuge in the shadow of your wings, may their souls be bound up in the bonds of life, may their descendants find consolation in our belated recognition of their suffering. God is their inheritance. May they rest in peace. Let us say, Amen.*

Continuing on the other side of the page. [Continues prayer] *Look around us search above us, below, behind. We stand in a great web of being joined together. Let us praise, let us love the life we are living, passing through us in the body of humanity and our own bodies, let's say Amen. Time flows through us like water, the past and the dead speak through us, we breathe out our children's children's blessing. Blessed is the earth from which we grow, blessed the life we are led. Blessed the ones who teach us, blessed the ones we teach. Blessed is the word that cannot begin to express the glory that shines through us and on past, distant suns forever. Let's say Amen. Blessed is light, blessed is darkness, but blessed above all else is peace which bears the fruits of knowledge on strong branches. Let's say Amen. Peace that carries joy into the world, peace that*

enables love, peace everywhere. Blessed and holy is peace. Let's say Amen.

[End of prayer] Thank you, please be seated. At the end of our ceremony today, we invite you—if you wish and it's not too muddy or to wet out there—to perform a custom which is very deeply traditional within Judaism, but again, accessible to everyone. **Verna Nine**, she's sitting over there with one of the small group, has brought some small stones, pebbles, and it's traditional in Judaism to place a pebble on the gravestone of one we are remembering, one we love or someone we're remembering. It's a custom that stems from ancient days in the land of Israel, when burials were mostly in caves, the caves had to remain sealed to keep out wild animals, and so when you visited the grave of someone that you loved, you would build up that barrier in front of the cave. So, we do that now as a mark of our continuing memory and love for those people, and that will be available to you today.

SD: I just went over and picked up one of the packets of stones, each one of the graves will receive at least two to three stones on the grave, and as they say, those stones will last and they will be there. So, you see the flowers at the bottom, we have a small unit of flowers that will go on each of the graves, and the stones. And those will be put on later by people here at the church because it's so wet that we can't go out there today and take care of that activity. But we do appreciate having this ceremony, we appreciate sharing the African culture with it. If you look at the set on the table there, we do have Africa represented with the little shawl that goes through the center, we have it there to recognize the individuals who lost their lives, who were good citizens—and that's what we

need to stress, these were hard-working, good, honest people. Four of them are buried here at this church cemetery. Also, you can go online, and we have mapped this whole cemetery, and you can look at the stones, just click on the link for the name, and when you click on the link for the name, then you will see the stone that is in the graveyard at this time. Thank you. Next, we will have a poem by Ms. Vivian Filer.

VF: I do appreciate the opportunity to be here because this is what it's all about. But I have to tell you from my heart, this is very hard. Don't ever think that African Americans get through this easily. It's very personal, it hurts. It hurts very much to relive it, for relive it we must, all of us have a lynching story. My dad in Old Town, Florida was almost lynched, but the sheriff in Trenton's brother went and got him and hid him so that he wouldn't get lynched. So, they're good people on both sides, but the stories go on, they go on and on, and they're personal and they're private, and they're painful. But we are willing, we're willing to go there, because we know if we don't go there, our children are never going to be free. Until we're all free, there are none of us free. So, we're—what we're doing today—you're gonna, I'm gonna have to apologize, I have to do this on my phone, I'm old, don't have good eyesight, a lot of things going on, but we're gonna get through this—but whatever I do, put it to the age. In case you're wondering, I'm eighty-one. Proud of it, but—[applause]—but the piece I'm gonna do is something from Paul Laurence Dunbar, I love Paul Laurence Dunbar. He was born a freedman, but his parents were enslaved, and but they told him the stories of what happened, so Paul Laurence Dunbar wrote in African Americans folk language, Standard

English, but he told stories that were near and dear. This story is about the men who did not fear to fight for their own freedom, they went to the blue lines and the blue lines took them in, but they were unsung, nobody gave them credit as our men are, those—the ones we're celebrating today were unsung, we're singing their story so that we all may know it and be able to work from it. [Begins poem]

A song for the unsung heroes who rose in the country's need, When the life of the land was threatened by the slaver's cruel greed, For the men who came from the cornfield, who came from the plough and the flail, who rallied round when they heard the sound of the mighty man of the rail. They laid them down in the valleys, they laid them down in the wood, And the world looked on at the work they did, and whispered, "It is good." They fought their way on the hillside, they fought their way in the glen, And God looked down on their sinews brown, and said, "I have made them men." They went to the blue lines gladly, and the blue lines took them in, And the song of the thundering canon was a sole requiem. The gray lines rose and melted beneath their scathing showers, and they said, "t'is true, they have force to do, these old slave boys of ours." Ah, Wagner saw their glory, that poured on a nation's altar, a sacrificial flood. Port Hudson heard their war cry that smote its smoke-filled air, and the old free fires of their savage sires again were kindled there. They laid them down where the rivers the greening valleys gem, and the song of the thundering cannon was their sole requiem. And the great smoke wreath that mingled its hue with the dusky cloud, Was the flag that furled o'er a saddened world, and the sheet that made their shroud. Oh, Mighty God of the battles who held them in Thy hand, who gave

them strength through the whole day's length, to fight for their native land. They are lying dead on the hillsides, they are lying dead on the plain, and we have not fire to smite the lyre and sing them one brief strain. Give, Thou, some seer the power to sing them in their might, the men who feared the master's whip, but did not fear the fight; That he may tell of their virtues as minstrels did of old, 'Til the pride of face and the hate of race grow obsolete and cold. A song for the unsung heroes who stood the awful test, When the humblest host that the world could boast went forth to meet the best; A song for the unsung heroes who fell on the bloody sod, who fought their way from night 'til day and then struggled up to God.

[Applause]

SD: God bless you for that. Thank you so much, it was very touching, very touching. We're to the point now of acknowledgments, and we have people that we would like to recognize. Ms. Linda Fields—are you here, Sister Fields? —made it possible for us to be here in this building tonight, and we want to say thank you, thank you. [Applause]

LF: I just want to say one thing, I spoke to Minister Eunice Meyers, she's a descendant of—let's see—Mary Dennis, Bert Dennis, and Jim, and I spoke to her, she was here at church for—she funeralized her son yesterday—and I spoke to her briefly about it, but she wanted me to share that she thanked you all so much for what you're doing, and she just—one thing that she wants to, hopefully we all strive forward, and she really wants to stop the violence. And she's a hundred years old, we had her huge birthday party on March 23, so to God be the glory. Thank you all so much. [Applause]

SD: Thank you, thank you. I want to ask again if we have any other family members from the Newberry Six here who've come in?

LF: I wanted to recognize other church members.

SD: Yes, please. Ms. Rush, stand up 'cause you made it so we could be here. Thank you. [Applause]

LF: Henry McCray. [Applause] Ivy back here, Ms. Adele Ivy, back here.

SD: Ms. Ivy, yes. Thank you.

LF: As well as my niece, India.

SD: Please stand so we can see you. [Applause] Thank you, thank you. Now, I do have something special that I have to say about Mr. McCray, because when I did this study—I did the Newberry study for the house and for the property to be considered for the state of Florida, and this was done in 2006 was when we finished the study, it was a two year study out here, and it was a very touching study, I don't talk much about it because it causes me to feel somewhat uneasy, but the truth is the light and a lot of things that I put in there were not used. And I say this before everybody who's here tonight. And, of course, now it is known as the Dudley Farm, and we're very happy that they have it and it's a state recognized situation, but when I interviewed the African Americans out here, they call it the plantation. They would not give it the respect of a farm, and many of the stories that were had and talked about were just unbearable. And I want you to know that Mr. McCray was one of the men that took us from place to place to get these stories, the Ross family was another one—there were several families, the McHenrys, the Welchs—so when we start talking about these atrocities, we only

talk about one family, you haven't heard about the Dudleys. Oh, but there were other families out here as well, and I can tell you who they were, and they were part of this situation. And this is the part that we ignore in history. These family members have had friends out here, and those friends and other families came out here and they were a part of all that has happened. They would send their slaves from one place to another to work during the day, they would send them out. So, there's a lot of history here that we are not talking about tonight because this is not the time for it, but there's so much more to African American history than just saying these six people were the ones that were lynched. There were others, as it has well been brought out in the past. I want to recognize—we have Senator Gracey here from Orlando—would you just— Gracey, would you stand for us? [Applause] Thank you, thank you so much for coming, Senator Gracey. We also have Senator Tony Hill and his wife; would you please stand? [Applause] Also, we have Stacy Peters, who's representing Levy County and the democratic process, would you please stand? [Applause] She has Debbie **Gool** who works with the newspaper in Levy County, so Levy County is recognized for the newspaper today. We also have the Gainesville Sun newspaper represented, and I don't see the young—oh, there she is—would you please stand so we can recognize you? [Applause] Thank you. And the cameraman, right there on the front row, and if we have other news people here, would you please just stand? I don't know maybe who you are, but if not, we thank all of you for coming, and I want you to know that everybody is special here today. Each and every one of us have to work together to make life livable for all of us. So, these are the folks that

we recognize, and I want you to take a moment and just pat yourself on the chest and say thank you for being here, thank you for being here. Thank you for being here because it took an effort for you to be with us today, and we say thank you. Our closing prayer will be Minister Isaiah Branton, and so Mr. Branton will be coming forward—and I must say before he gets here, so much of our research done in this area would not have been done without this man. He took us from place to place, making sure we were able to talk to the right people, making sure we were able to get the kind of information that had not been shared before with the general public—so Mr. Branton, Reverend Branton, Minister Branton, Brother Branton, I say thank you.

B: Good evening. I thank God for being here. My family was also out here in Jonesville and is buried—Louise Perry Hale, that was my mother's second cousin, and also my great great grandmother was **Fanny Perry's** mother, so I got a lot of history out in Jonesville. Also we were the Chisms and the Perrys and a lot of people—even the Longs—we were associated with them, my grandmother Susie Jackson was a midwife that came out here and tended to the lady that was pregnant that was killed. So, I know a lot of history—my grandmother lived to be a hundred and three, so she told me a lot. Okay, we go—I'm gonna do what I was called to do, close the prayer. So, let us just stand and grab each other hand and be in unity as I pray. [Begins prayer] *Heavenly Father God, Father, we come in the name of Jesus, Father, knowing that you're all mighty and powerful. In you we live, we move, and we have our being. Father, we come forward to asking you to look, look on the honorees, the ones that we*

remembered, the ones that was unjustly lynched, God. Father, just look on look on their family, and continue and bless their family, let us look at the past as a growing card, that we may grow from it, we may learn from it, and we may be moved boldly to stand up and be—have justice in our hearts. Still the hating and despair, that we may rise above all our ignorance and our misunderstanding, that we may walk by faith and look at a person as a human being, someone who lives and someone who breathes, someone not treated like an animal or someone treated like a cow or a hog—but we're looking at a human being, at someone who is a human, and that we are the people of Kush that—we built the pyramids, but we were bought over here as slaves, from the pyramid to the slaughter. So, but God, just continue to look on us, God, continue to bless us, God, continue—after four hundred years, Lord, Father continue to hold my eyes up and continue to hold our adversaries eyes up that we're not oppressed because of who we are, we're oppressed because somebody hate us because of lack of knowledge. And Father, continue to feed them knowledge, let this United States become united, and let it become blessed. A house divided will fall; Father, we want to stand together in unity, God, and we want to run hate out of here. We want to tell hate that you have no room, and Father, continue to bless us and keep us, God. Father, as I close this prayer, let the words in my mouth, the meditation of my heart, be acceptable in thy sight, oh Lord, my strength and my redeemer. Amen.

[End of prayer] Amen, thank you. [Applause]

[End of interview]

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